CHAPTER 5

IS THERE INTELLIGENT LIFE ON EARTH?

They journeyed a long time and found nothing. At length they discerned a small light, which was the Earth … [But] they could not find the smallest reason to suspect that we and our fellow-citizens of this globe have the honor to exist.

—VOLTAIRE, *MICROMEGAS. A PHILOSOPHICAL HISTORY* (1752)

There are places, in and around our great cities, where the natural world has all but disappeared. You can make out streets and sidewalks, autos, parking garages, advertising billboards, monuments of glass and steel, but not a tree or a blade of grass or any animal—besides, of course, the humans. There are lots of humans. Only when you look straight up through the skyscraper canyons can you make out a star or a patch of blue—reminders of what was there long before humans came to be. But the bright lights of the big cities bleach out the stars, and even that patch of blue is sometimes gone, tinted brown by industrial technology.

It's not hard, going to work every day in such a place, to be impressed with ourselves. How we've transformed the Earth for our benefit and convenience! But a few hundred miles up or down there are no humans. Apart from a thin film of life at the very surface of the Earth, an occasional intrepid spacecraft, and some radio static, our impact on the Universe is nil. It knows nothing of us.